

made me a singer. Music was within me. I was full of it."

Lata Mangeshkar

Singer 1929

VOICE OF INDIA

A composer's dream, her singing, sometimes playful and at other times poignant, has been an integral part of the nation's soundtrack

■ By Khayyam

Every music composer always has something specific in mind while devising a tune and wants the singer to deliver accordingly. The mark of a perfect singer is when he or she understands this intuitively. Lata Mangeshkar is one such singer—a composer's dream. Whenever I hear her sing I always feel that the Almighty has especially bestowed her with a magical voice.

I remember the film that made people sit up and take notice of her. It was Bombay Talkies' *Majboor* in 1948. The music director was Master Ghulam Haider and the two songs that he made a very young Lata sing were *Piya milne ko aa* and *Dil mera toda*. She had sung some Marathi and Hindi songs before that but they had gone largely unnoticed. But when the great maestro Haider chose her, everybody got curious. I was one of them. One day I asked him what he thought the future held for this new singer. He said with her undoubted talent, assignments would come her way but she would have to remain level headed if she wanted to excel. That is exactly how she remained—humble. It was another film by another great that brought out the magical quality inherent in her voice. The film was Kamal Amrohi's *Mahal* and the song was the immortal *Aayega aane wala*. Real life almost imitated reel life after this film. Just as Ashok Kumar was drawn to Madhubala's mesmerising voice in the film, the audience became

enchanted by Lata's rendition. After the film's stupendous success she became the voice of Madhubala.

Soon every actor wanted her voice. But she was always busy and only a few fortunate music directors got the chance to make her sing. I approached her many times but she remained unavailable due to prior appointments. I finally got to work with her in Nargis Arts' *Pyaar Ki Baatein* in 1951, in which she sung two songs. But it was with Amrohi's 12-years-in-the-making *Razia Sultan*

that our pairing became successful. The first song we recorded for the film was *Ae dil-e-nadaan* and such was the magic of her voice that even before the film was released, the entire industry was talking about it. Once, quite late in the night, Jaya Bachchan and actor Shammi came to my house because Amitabh had been pestering the two to get him the song. Soon after this incident, Yash Chopra asked me to compose the music for *Kabhi Kabhie*. Till *Kabhi Kabhie* the films I had given music for had become hits and I had got recognition but this one was the first golden jubilee of my career. I recall asking Lata to pray for the film to be a success. In her trademark voice she told me my prayers would be answered—and indeed they were.

Every music director, however big or small, is the same for her. She rehearses for every song with equal dedication. Even when she is extremely happy with a tune she never overtly expresses her joy. Whenever she really likes a song, she breaks into a slight smile and starts blushing. These two are the only indicators of her really liking a tune. She never says anything; it's her eyes that light up. I have had the good fortune to work with a living legend—someone who is not only renowned in India but whose fame has now spread to the entire world. Till the time she can, Lata should sing.

as told to Jhilmil Motihar

The author worked with Mangeshkar on films like *Razia Sultan* and *Kabhi Kabhie*



Q: What was she named at birth?

A: Hema. Her parents later renamed her one of her father's plays, *Bhaawbandhan*. Lata after a female character Latika in

Q: When did she set out to get her Urdu accent right?

A: When Dilip Kumar remarked on her "very Mahatrashtrian" accent, she took lessons in Urdu from a maulvi.

Q: What is said to be the secret of her sweet voice?

A: Chillies

Q: Who are her famous musical siblings?

A: Hridayanath, Asha, Usha, and Meena

Q: Where was she born?

A: Sikh mohalla, Indore